

By M.G. Radhakrishnan

Shanavas Mammed Koya, 27, was sleeping in his Dubai flat on a Saturday morning when incessant calls from his panicked relatives in Kozhikode, Kerala, awoke him. That was when the stunned young man first learnt of the tragedy that befell 158 passengers aboard the Air India Express IX 812, from Dubai to Mangalore, on May 22. What was more shocking was that tv channels flashed passport details of dead passengers, including Koya's. He hurriedly contacted the Indian Consulate and learnt that Abdul Samad, one of the dead, was travelling on a fake passport which bore Koya's passport number and address. "I have my passport with me and the Consulate has confirmed its authenticity. My wife told me that people were flocking at our home to condole my death," Koya, who works at an investment firm based in the Jabel Ali Free Trade Zone.

The passport in question was issued by what locals refer to as the Kasargod Embassy, an euphemism for a massive and widespread racket that has flourished for years in the Gulf. This sleepy district in Kerala's northern tip was the worst hit when the Air India Express flight crashed. Of the 54 persons from Kerala killed in the tragedy, as many as 52 were from Kasargod. Most were working in Gulf countries. There were at least 10 passengers who were travelling on fake passports and now their families' will have trouble claiming the Rs 75 lakh compensation from the airline.

"This has been in operation since 1980s and has roots in the Gulf, though most of its organisers and users are from Kerala, which has about 20 lakh expatriates employed there. The term Kasargod Embassy has found its way into official documents," says K. Padma Kumar, IC (Intelligence), Kerala Police, who is in-charge of immigration at all the three international airports—Kozhikode, Kochi and Thiruvananthapuram—in the state. He says that a passport can be bought anywhere from Rs 65,000 to Rs 70,000 and is usually



Republic of KASARGOD

It took the Mangalore crash to expose a racket in fake passports used by labourers working in the Gulf

bought by poorer migrants.

Around 100 people get caught every year at Kerala's international airports and Kozhikode tops the list with 40-50 seizures a year. Some months ago a person was nabbed by the Customs Department with as many

as 31 passports. Officials of the Immigration Department say that most passports can make do with a photo substitution. The photograph of the original owner is replaced by that of the new owner. It's called *thala vettal* (head chopping) in local parlance. Such